

WHAT TO SAY

What to Say

*Sixty letters for the moments
nobody teaches you how to write.*

MURTAZA RAZA

What to Say

Copyright © 2026 Murtaza Raza. All rights reserved.

The moral right of the compiler has been asserted. No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form without written permission, except for brief quotations in a review.

The quotations collected here are drawn overwhelmingly from material out of copyright. Lines from writers still in copyright are quoted briefly and with attribution, as fair dealing for the purposes of criticism and review. Attributions have been checked against primary sources where those exist; where a line is disputed, paraphrased or traditional it is marked as such in the text and in the note on attribution at the back. The commentary is original.

First edition

Set in EB Garamond. Printed and bound on demand.

CONTENTS

How to Use This Book	1
----------------------	---

PART I · WHEN SOMETHING HAS HAPPENED

1	Condolence	5
2	Illness, and Other People's Bad News	11

PART II · WHEN YOU WERE WRONG

3	Apologising Properly	19
4	Owning It at Work	25

PART III · WHEN YOU WANT SOMETHING

5	Asking	33
6	Chasing	39

PART IV · WHEN THE ANSWER IS NO

7	Declining	47
8	Ending It	53

PART V · MONEY

9	Money Between People	61
10	Money With Institutions	67

PART VI · WHEN NOTHING IS WRONG

11	Praise and Thanks	75
12	Letters With No Purpose	81

END MATTER

	A Note on Using These	89
	Index of Situations	91

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Book

This is a book of sixty letters for the moments nobody teaches you how to write. A colleague's father has died. You owe somebody an apology you have been avoiding for a month. A friend has cancer. You have to ask for money, or refuse to lend it, or tell a landlord that the boiler has been broken since October. You want to end something without being cruel about it.

Each entry has four parts. The situation, in one line. The form of letter it needs. The letter itself, written out in full. And a short note on what is actually doing the work, because a letter you copy without understanding will fail the moment your circumstances differ from the example by an inch.

These are not templates. Or rather, they are, and using them as templates is the one way to get less out of the book than it contains. The names are invented and so are the details. Send one unaltered and it will read like a form letter, which is worse than a clumsy letter in your own words. What is transferable is the shape: what goes first, what is left out, where the offer belongs, and which sentence is carrying the weight. That is what the note after each letter is for.

On the notes. They are the argument of the book. Nearly all of them come back to the same handful of principles, and you will start to notice them: be specific instead of warm, because specificity is how warmth is proved. Remove the recipient's obligation to reply, above all when they are suffering. Do not explain yourself at length, because explanation is a

request for absolution wearing a disguise. Say the thing in the first three lines. Offer something concrete rather than something general.

On length. Most of these are shorter than the letter you would have written unaided, and that is deliberate. The instinct under pressure is to add: more sympathy, more context, more mitigation. Almost every letter in this book got better when a paragraph came out of it, and the paragraph that came out was nearly always the one about the writer.

On apologies in particular. Chapters three and four take a harder line than is fashionable. An apology containing an explanation is not an apology, it is a defence with an apology attached, and the recipient can always tell. If you take one thing from this book, take that.

What a letter cannot do. It cannot make a bereavement smaller, get you forgiven by somebody who has decided not to forgive you, or make a decision land softly when the decision itself is hard. Several letters here are written in full knowledge that they will not be well received, and their job is only to be honest, clear and unpaddable. A letter that succeeds is not always a letter that gets you what you want.

Send it. The common failure is not the badly written letter. It is the letter that was never written, because the moment passed, or the right words did not come, or it seemed too late. It is rarely too late. Somebody who is grieving in the third month, or who has not been thanked in twenty years, is not waiting for the perfect version.

Open it at whichever chapter matches the thing you are avoiding.

I

WHEN SOMETHING HAS HAPPENED



Condolence

The reason condolence letters go unwritten is not that people do not care. It is that they are afraid of getting it wrong, and the fear of getting it wrong produces the one outcome that is certainly wrong. Silence.

Nearly everybody who has been bereaved will tell you the same two things afterwards. The letters mattered more than they expected, including the clumsy ones. And the people who said nothing left a mark that lasted. They did not mean to. They were waiting until they could think of something adequate.

Nothing is adequate. That is the first thing to accept, and it is liberating rather than defeating. You are not going to write the sentence that helps, because no such sentence exists. What you are doing is much smaller and within reach: telling somebody that their loss has been noticed, by a person who is not obliged to notice.

There are four things that go in a condolence letter and one thing that does not. Say who has died, by name. Say something specific about them, or if you did not know them, about what the person has told you of them. Offer one concrete thing, not a general offer. And close without asking for anything.

The thing that does not go in is a question. A bereaved person is answering forty messages while arranging a funeral. A letter that needs an answer is one more job. Do not give them a job.

Send it late. Two months on, when everybody else has stopped, is when the letters are worth most.

001

“Your close friend’s mother has died. You knew her a little.”

Condolence, where you knew them

THE LETTER

Dear Priya,

I am so sorry about your mum. I keep thinking about that afternoon in the garden when she made us all move the table twice and then decided the first place had been right, and how much she laughed at herself about it. She was very funny, and she was very kind to me when I did not know anyone.

I am not going to pretend to know what this is like. I am around, and I will keep being around in a few months when it goes quiet, which I gather is the hard part.

I will drop some food off on Thursday and leave it on the step. No need to come to the door and no need to reply to this.

With love, Alex

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The specific memory. It says *I knew her, and here is proof*, which is the thing a bereaved person is most starved of once the funeral is over and everybody reverts to generalities. Second is the promise about later, because the support collapses at about week three and everyone knows it. Third is the food with the door shut in advance: an offer that requires nothing, not even the effort of being seen.

002

“A colleague’s father has died. You have met them twice and never met him.”

Condolence, at a distance

THE LETTER

Dear Sam,

I have just heard about your father and I wanted to say how sorry I am.

CONDOLENCE

We do not know each other well, so I will not pretend to a closeness we do not have. I hope you are being looked after, and that work is the least of your concerns at the moment.

Everything on the Fenwick account is covered. Rob has it and there is nothing outstanding that needs you. Please do not think about any of it.

Take whatever time you need.

Sam, with sympathy, Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The honesty about distance. Overclaiming intimacy is the commonest failure in professional condolence, and it reads as false at once. Naming the gap and writing anyway is warmer than pretending. The second half is the real gift: a colleague's dominant anxiety is that things are falling apart in their absence, and removing that is worth more than any sentiment.

003

“Someone’s baby died before it was born.”

Condolence, for a loss others may not name

THE LETTER

Dear Ellie,

I heard about the baby and I am so terribly sorry.

I know some people will not mention it, and I did not want to be one of them. She was real and she was yours and you were going to be her mother.

I am not going to say any of the things people say. I do not think there is anything that helps.

I love you. I am here whenever, for anything, including for talking about her, if you ever want to.

Ellie x

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the child, and using the word *she*. Losses like this are handled by everyone around them as though they were medical events and not deaths,

and the result is that the bereaved parent is left alone with a grief nobody has acknowledged as grief. The line about not saying the things people say is doing something too: it tells her you know the standard consolations are useless, which means you are safe to talk to.

004

“An old friend you have not seen in years has lost their partner.”

Condolence, after a long silence

THE LETTER

Dear Tom,

We have not spoken in far too long and I am sorry that this is what brings me back. I heard about Jamie and I am so sorry.

I only met him twice, at your fortieth and at that awful barbecue, and both times I came away thinking you had done extraordinarily well.

I am not writing to reappear in your life or to make you manage an old friendship on top of everything else. I only wanted you to know that somebody who has known you since we were nineteen is thinking about you.

If you ever want a walk with someone who has no opinions about any of it, I am at the same number.

Tom, I am sorry. Alex

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Addressing the awkwardness of the gap in the first line, so it stops being the elephant. Then lifting the obligation to reciprocate, out loud, which is what stops people writing after a long silence: the fear of imposing a resumed friendship on somebody at their worst. Naming that fear and disclaiming it makes the letter a gift rather than a demand.

005

“You have missed it. The funeral was six weeks ago.”

Condolence, late

THE LETTER

Dear Rachel,

This is late, and I am not going to explain why, because the reasons are not interesting and they are not really reasons.

I have been thinking about your dad and about you.

My guess, from the little I know, is that the phone has stopped ringing by now and the house is quieter than it was in November. If that is right, I hope somebody is still checking on you.

I am, from a distance, and with no expectation of a reply.

Rachel, with love, Sarah

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Refusing to explain the delay. Explanations turn a condolence letter into a letter about you, and the bereaved person then has to absolve you, which is another job. The other move is the guess about the phone having stopped: it demonstrates that you have thought about what this week is like for her, not what the week of the funeral was like, and that is exactly what late letters are for.

Illness, and Other People's Bad News

Bad news that is not a death has a particular problem attached to it, which is that nobody knows what the form is. A death has rituals: cards exist, there is a funeral, there is a moment when writing is expected. A diagnosis has none of that. A marriage ending has none of that. A redundancy has none of that. So the news travels. Everyone decides in private that it is not their place, and the person at the centre of it experiences a strange quiet. That quiet is the thing people describe years afterwards, more often than they describe the diagnosis or the solicitor's letter or the meeting in the small room with somebody from HR in it, and it is made up entirely of individually reasonable decisions not to intrude.

The other problem is optimism. The instinct on hearing that somebody is ill is to say something hopeful, and hope offered too soon reads as a request. *You'll beat this* asks the person to be brave on your behalf, because you would find their fear difficult. The commonest thing people with a serious diagnosis report wanting is somebody who does not need them to be positive about it.

So these letters do less than instinct suggests. They acknowledge the fact, avoid forecasting, and offer something specific. The specific offer matters more here than anywhere else in this book, because the ill and the newly unemployed are both drowning in vague ones. *Let me know if there is anything I can do* transfers the work of thinking to the person with the least capacity for it. It sounds generous. It is not.

Say what you will do, name a day, and then do it.

006

“A friend has been diagnosed with something serious.”

Writing to someone who is ill

THE LETTER

Dear Nadia,

Ben told me yesterday. I am so sorry. What a frightening thing to be told.

I am not going to tell you that you will be fine, because I do not know that and you have probably had enough of it from people who also do not know it. Whatever this turns out to be, it is allowed to be as bad as it is.

Practical things: I am going to drop a bag of proper food round on Sunday morning, and I will do it every Sunday until you tell me to stop. If you would rather I did not, say so and I will not be offended, but the default is that I am coming.

I would love to see you when you are up to it. There is no rush and no obligation, and I will not read anything into a slow reply.

All my love, Kate

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Refusing the forecast. Saying *it is allowed to be as bad as it is* gives permission almost nobody offers. It is the thing ill people most often say they wish somebody had said. Then the offer with a default in it: not *would you like food* but *food is coming, tell me to stop*, which removes the burden of asking.

007

“Somebody’s marriage has ended and you are friends with both.”

When you do not know whose side to take

THE LETTER

Dear Chris,

I heard about you and Fran. I am sorry. Whatever the details, I know it will not have been easy to get here.

I want to be straight with you, because I would rather say it than have you wonder. I am not going to take a side, and I have said the same to her. That is not neutrality about how you are; I care about you a great deal. It just means I am not the person to discuss the whys with.

What I can be is somebody you get a curry with who does not mention it once, if that is useful.

I am about most Thursdays.

Chris, Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Saying the awkward thing instead of hoping it will not come up, and saying it early. Friends of both parties go quiet because they cannot face this conversation, and the going quiet is experienced as a second loss. The other move is offering the specific thing a newly separated person is least likely to be offered: an evening where nobody mentions it.

008

“A colleague has been made redundant.”

After a redundancy

THE LETTER

Dear Priya,

WHAT TO SAY

I only heard this morning and I am sorry. For what it is worth, everybody I have spoken to has said some version of the same thing, which is that it makes no sense and it is not a reflection of your work.

Three specific offers, all of which stand for as long as you want them.

I will write you a reference today, and I mean a real one, not a template. Say the word.

I know two people at Halden and one at the Trust, and I am happy to introduce you to any of them, or all three.

And if you would rather not think about work at all for a month, that is also completely reasonable and I will stop sending you things.

I am sorry, Priya. It is genuinely their loss.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Three named offers instead of one vague one, each small enough to accept without embarrassment. The last of the three is the one that matters most and is almost never given: explicit permission to not job-hunt yet. Everybody else in her inbox is being helpful in a way that assumes urgency, and the effect is a person who cannot rest.

009

“A friend’s child is in hospital.”

To a parent, mid-crisis

THE LETTER

Ellie,

No need to read this now or ever.

I am not going to ask how he is, because you are answering that question thirty times a day and I do not want to be the thirty-first.

I have put twenty pounds of credit on the hospital car park app under your registration. There is also a bag with phone chargers, a blanket, decent coffee and paracetamol at the ward reception with your name on it.

I am going to text you one thing every day. It will not need a reply, it will just be something normal and stupid so your phone does something other than deliver bad news.

I love you both. Say nothing back.

Sarah

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Not asking. A parent in a hospital spends the whole day being asked for an update they do not have. The letter that does not ask is remembered for years. Everything else is logistics: car park credit, chargers, coffee, all things that are unbearable to arrange from inside a ward and trivial to arrange from outside one.

010

“Somebody’s parent has dementia and it is going to go on for years.”

The illness with no end date

THE LETTER

Dear Tom,

I have been thinking about you and your mum.

I know this is not the kind of news that comes with a moment. There is no day when people send cards, and I imagine the hardest part is that it is a loss that keeps happening rather than one that happened.

I am not going to disappear after the initial flurry. I have put a reminder in my phone to check on you on the first of every month, which is either a nice thing or a slightly clinical thing depending on your mood, and I am telling you because I want you to know it is deliberate.

No obligation to answer any of them.

Love, Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the shape of the illness: a loss that keeps happening rather than one that happened. People with degenerative diagnoses in the family say the isolating part is that there is no event, so nobody knows when to be kind. Admitting the reminder in the phone sounds unromantic and lands as the opposite, because it is a promise with a mechanism behind it.

II

WHEN YOU WERE WRONG

Apologising Properly

Most apologies fail for one of three reasons. All three are about the writer.

The first is the conditional. *I am sorry if you were upset* makes the injury hypothetical and locates it in the other person's reaction rather than in your conduct. Everybody hears it. Nobody says so, because objecting to an apology is not a thing you can do.

The second is the explanation. You describe the pressure you were under, the misunderstanding, the thing you had going on that week. Every word of it may be true and all of it functions as a defence, which converts an apology into a case. The reader can either accept the case, in which case there was nothing to apologise for, or reject it, in which case they are being unreasonable about your difficult month.

The third is the request. *I hope we can put this behind us* asks for forgiveness in the same breath as offering the apology, which means the apology has a price. A real apology is given without terms and the other person decides what happens next.

So the shape that works is short and uncomfortable: name what you did, without softening it. Say what was wrong with it, in a way that shows you understand the damage and not just the rule. Say what you will do instead. And then stop, without asking for anything at all.

Under a hundred words beats over three hundred. Length reads as pleading.

“You said something cruel during an argument and you meant it at the time.”

The apology for something you meant

THE LETTER

Rachel,

I said you were exactly like your mother, and I said it because I knew it would hurt you, and it did.

That was not a slip. I was losing and I reached for the thing I knew would land. It is the worst thing about how I argue and it is not the first time.

I am not asking you to be all right about it. You do not have to answer this or forgive it on any timetable.

I am seeing someone about the way I get in arguments. I started before this, which is not an excuse, but I want you to know it is not just a thing I am saying now.

I am sorry, Rachel. It was cruel and you did not deserve it.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Admitting the intent. Most apologies for cruelty describe it as a loss of control, because *I did not mean it* is easier to say and easier to hear. It is also untrue, and the other person knows it, which is why the standard apology does not land. Owning the deliberateness is the only version that is believable, and the absence of any request at the end is what makes it a gift rather than a transaction.

012

“You forgot something that mattered enormously to somebody.”

The forgotten occasion

THE LETTER

Dear Mum,

I forgot. There is no version of this where I did not just forget, and I am not going to dress it up as being busy, because I was not doing anything that mattered more than your seventieth.

I know you will say it is fine. It is not fine, and I would rather you were annoyed with me than that you pretended.

I have booked the Saturday after next, if you are free, and I will come to you. Not as a replacement, which it is not, but because I want to see you.

I am sorry. I love you.

Alex

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Pre-empting the forgiveness. *I know you will say it is fine* refuses the escape route the injured party offers to make things comfortable, and it is the difference between an apology and a small piece of theatre. Note also that the proposed date is not offered as making up for it, since claiming to repair something is a way of closing it early.

013

“You let a colleague down and it cost them.”

Professional apology, where there are consequences

THE LETTER

Dear Sam,

I did not send the figures on Thursday and you went into the board meeting without them. That was my error and it made you look unprepared for something that was not your fault.

I have spoken to Ruth this morning and told her the delay was mine, in those words, so the record is straight.

The reason it happened is not interesting and I will not take up your time with it. What I have changed is that anything with a board deadline now sits in the shared calendar with a two-day buffer, so it does not depend on me remembering.

I am sorry, Sam. It should not have landed on you.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Correcting the record with the third party, and saying so. In a professional apology the damage is reputational, so an apology that stays private repairs nothing. Second, refusing to explain: *the reason is not interesting* is a deliberate closing of the door that most people leave open, and it signals that you are not looking for absolution.

014

“You said something confidently in public and it was wrong.”

The correction

THE LETTER

All,

In Tuesday’s meeting I said the renewal rate was above ninety percent. It is seventy-six. I was working from last year’s dashboard and I did not check it before I said it.

That number was load-bearing for the decision we took about hiring, and I would want us to revisit that in light of the real figure. I have put the correct dashboard in the shared drive.

Apologies for the noise, and for the confidence with which I said it.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Correcting it to the same audience that heard the error, at the same volume, without being asked. The last line is the one that costs something: apologising not for the error but for the certainty. Being confidently wrong damages a room's ability to calibrate you, and naming it is what repairs it.

015

“It has been years and you have never apologised.”

The late apology

THE LETTER

Dear Chris,

This is about something from 2011, so you may have to think for a moment to remember it, or you may not.

I told a room of people about your brother when you had asked me not to. I have thought about it a great many times since.

I am not writing because I want anything, and I do not expect a reply. I would rather you had the apology than that I kept being comfortable about not giving it. If you would prefer not to hear from me, this will be the last time.

I was twenty-four and that is an explanation rather than a defence.

I am sorry. It was a betrayal and I knew it at the time.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Disclaiming the reply in the letter itself, and meaning it. Most late apologies are a request for relief dressed as remorse, and the recipient feels the difference at once. Offering to disappear is the proof of good faith: it says the apology is for them and not for your comfort, which is the only thing that makes a fifteen-year-old letter welcome rather than intrusive.

Owning It at Work

The instinct with a work mistake is to wait. Not out of dishonesty. There is a version of the future in which the problem solves itself and nobody ever has to know, and that version is always available and always tempting.

It is worth being clear-eyed about the arithmetic. A problem disclosed early is a problem the organisation can still do something about, and disclosing it makes you a person with judgement. The same problem discovered later is a problem plus a concealment, and the concealment is what people remember. The gap between those two outcomes is enormous. It is a function of how long you waited.

The letters here share one structural feature, which is that the bad news goes in the first sentence. Not the context, not the background, not the mitigations. The fact, before anything else. Anybody who has ever received one of these will tell you that the paragraph of preamble before the actual news is unbearable, because the reader knows something is coming and is now waiting for it while being told about the weather.

Then, in order: what it means, what you have already done, what you need from them. Four short paragraphs. And no apology longer than a sentence, because at work an extended apology reads as a request to be reassured, and the person receiving it has a problem to manage.

016

“You are going to miss a deadline and it is still three weeks away.”

Bad news, early

THE LETTER

Ruth,

The migration is not going to be ready for the fifteenth. My honest estimate is the twenty-ninth.

I am telling you now rather than at the end because there is still time to do something with it. If the fifteenth is immovable, we could ship the read-only version on time and follow with the rest, which I think is the better of the bad options.

What went wrong: I scoped the data cleaning at four days and it is nearer twelve. That is an estimating failure and it is mine.

I am free any time today to talk it through.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Telling them three weeks out, not three days. The value of the letter is in its timing, and the second paragraph makes that explicit by offering something that is only possible because there is still runway. Note that the failure is named in one line and not defended, which leaves the rest of the message for the part your manager needs. Options.

017

“You have made an expensive mistake and nobody has noticed yet.”

Escalating your own error

THE LETTER

Ruth,

I have made an error that has cost us somewhere around eleven thousand pounds. Nobody outside my team knows yet and I wanted you to hear it from me first.

I approved the second print run without checking the amended artwork, so four thousand units carry the old address. They are in the warehouse.

What I have done already: stopped the third run, spoken to the printer about a reprint at cost, which they have agreed to, and had a sticker solution priced at nine hundred pounds in case we want to salvage the stock.

What I need from you: a decision on reprint versus stickers, and whether you want to tell Adam or you would rather I did.

I am sorry. It was a check I should have done and did not.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The number first. Before any explanation. Managers report that the delay in getting to the figure is the part that erodes trust, because it feels like being managed. The section that changes the letter's reception is *what I have done already*: it converts you from the source of a problem into the person handling it, and it is why this letter survives an eleven thousand pound mistake.

018

"A client's project is late and it is your fault."

The client apology

THE LETTER

Dear Sarah,

The site will not be live on the third. It will be live on the seventeenth, and I am confident about that date in a way I was evidently not entitled to be about the last one.

This is our failure, not a supplier issue and not a scope issue. We under-resourced the build.

What we are doing: two additional developers started on it yesterday, and I am personally reviewing progress against the plan every Friday, which I will send you whether or not there is anything to report.

What I am not going to do is ask you to be understanding. You have a launch to run and this has made it harder.

We are not invoicing the March retainer.

I am sorry, Sarah. Ring me any time.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Refusing to ask for understanding, which is what almost every client apology does and what clients find most irritating about them. Then a cost borne in public: waiving the retainer converts the apology from words into a number, which is the currency the relationship runs on. The offer of the weekly update *whether or not there is anything to report* addresses the real fear, which is silence.

019

“You reacted badly to being passed over and people saw.”

Apologising for your reaction

THE LETTER

Dear Priya,

I was short with you in the stand-up on Wednesday and I have been off with you since, and it is because you got the lead and I wanted it.

That is not your fault and it is not a reflection of anything you did. You were the right choice and I would have made the same one.

I am not writing this to be told it was fine, because it was not, and I am aware that an apology that arrives with an explanation attached can read as a request for sympathy. It is not.

Congratulations, properly this time. I would like to work on it with you if you will still have me.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the actual cause. Everybody in the room already knows why you were short, so an apology that omits the reason is incomplete, and reads as an insult. Saying it out loud is the thing that costs you and the thing that repairs it. The pre-emption of *I am not fishing for reassurance* is doing real work too, because that is exactly what this letter would otherwise look like.

020

“You have taken on something you cannot do.”

Asking to be taken off it

THE LETTER

Ruth,

I need to come off the compliance workstream. I am not able to do it well and I have been slow to say so.

This is not workload. I do not have the regulatory background it needs, and I have spent six weeks learning things that somebody with the right experience would already know. The work is about three weeks behind where it should be and that gap will grow.

I should have said this in week two. I did not because I thought I could close it, and by the time it was clear I could not, admitting it had got harder.

I am happy to hand over properly, and I would like to stay on the parts that are within what I can do.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Distinguishing incapacity from overload, which almost nobody does, because *I am too busy* is the permitted version and *I cannot do this* is not. The admission about the delay is the second half of the honesty: naming that the difficulty of confessing grew with time is the sentence that makes the letter credible rather than merely awkward.

III

WHEN YOU WANT SOMETHING

Asking

Most people are far more willing to help than most people expect. The research on this is consistent enough to state as a fact. Askers underestimate how often they will get a yes, by a wide margin, in every setting anybody has tested.

Which means the main obstacle to asking is not the risk of refusal. It is the discomfort of the twenty seconds before you send it. That discomfort produces a style of letter you will recognise: long, apologetic, hedged, and so anxious to give the reader an escape route that it suggests, by accident, that the whole thing is not worth doing.

The letters in this chapter are short. Not as a preference. As the mechanism. A long request signals that the asker knows they are imposing, which invites the reader to agree. A short one signals that the ask is ordinary, and most of them are.

Three things go in a good ask. The specific thing you want, stated as a request rather than hinted at. Why you are asking this person rather than anybody else, which is what makes it flattering instead of mass-produced. And an easy no, offered once, briefly, at the end. Once, not three times: an escape route repeated becomes a suggestion.

Do not apologise for asking in the first line. It sets the reader up to feel imposed upon before they know what for.

021

“You want a pay rise.”

Asking for money from your employer

THE LETTER

Ruth,

I would like to ask for a rise to sixty-two thousand, and I would like to talk about it properly rather than in a corridor. Could we book half an hour in the next fortnight?

The short version of the case: I took on the compliance reporting in March when Dev left, which was not in my role, and it has stayed with me. The audit went through with no findings for the first time in four years. And I am currently the only person who can run the reconciliation, which is a risk for you as well as an argument for me.

I have looked at what the role pays elsewhere and sixty-two is at the middle rather than the top of it.

Happy to send anything that would be useful ahead of the conversation.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

A number in the first sentence. Requests that circle the figure force the manager to guess, and they will guess low. Then the case in three specific facts, not adjectives, including one that is framed as the employer’s problem rather than the employee’s merit. The phrase *at the middle rather than the top* is modest on purpose and makes the number harder to argue with.

022

“You want a favour from somebody senior you barely know.”

Asking a stranger

THE LETTER

Dear Professor Adeyemi,

We met briefly at the Warwick symposium in June; I asked the question about the longitudinal data.

I am writing to ask whether you would be willing to spend twenty minutes on a call looking at my sampling design. I am at the stage where the errors are still cheap to fix, and you are the person whose 2019 paper made me realise the approach I had was wrong.

If the answer is no or not now, that is completely fine and I will not follow up.

With thanks either way,

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

A bounded ask: twenty minutes, one specific question, not *pick your brain*. Senior people decline vague requests because they cannot see the bottom of them. The reference to the specific paper is what separates this from a mass email. *I will not follow up* removes the main reason busy people ignore requests, which is the fear of an obligation that never ends.

023

“You want an introduction.”

Asking someone to spend their credibility

THE LETTER

Dear Sam,

Would you be willing to introduce me to Nadia Rahim at Halden? No obligation at all, and I would rather you said no than felt you had to.

I am asking because you have worked with her and I have not, and a cold approach from me will go in the same folder as everybody else’s.

To make it easy, here is something you could forward, if you would rather not write anything yourself:

“Nadia, this is Murtaza, who ran the reconciliation project I mentioned last year. He is looking at the same problem you described at the conference and I thought you two should talk. Murtaza, Nadia.”

Genuinely fine if not.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Writing the introduction for them. Introduction requests go unanswered for one reason. Composing the email is a small task that never reaches the top of anybody's list. Removing that work is the difference between a request that happens and one that does not. The easy no matters more here than elsewhere, because an introduction spends the other person's reputation.

024

“You are struggling and need to ask for help.”

Asking for something you find humiliating to need

THE LETTER

Sarah,

I need some help and I have been putting off asking, which is why this is a message rather than a conversation.

Things have been bad since January. I am managing work and almost nothing else, and the flat has got away from me in a way I am embarrassed about.

What would actually help is if you came over on a Saturday and we did the kitchen and the paperwork pile together. Not you doing it. Together, with the radio on, so that it is four hours rather than a thing I keep not starting.

I am also going to the doctor on the eleventh.

I am sorry to land this on you. If it is too much, say so and I will not be hurt.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

A concrete task instead of a general appeal. *I am struggling* leaves the friend wanting to help and with no idea how, and the commonest outcome is a supportive message and nothing else. Naming a specific afternoon and a specific job converts sympathy into action. The line about the doctor signals, without saying it, that the friend is not being asked to be the whole solution.

025

“You want someone to be a reference.”

Asking for a name

THE LETTER

Dear Ruth,

Would you be willing to act as a reference for me? The role is Head of Operations at the Trust and they are likely to ring rather than write.

I am asking you rather than Adam because the job is mostly about the reporting side, which you saw more of.

Two things that would help, if you are happy to: they are interested in whether I can run a team through a change programme, and the Fenwick migration is the best example of that. And it would be reasonable for them to ask about the compliance workstream I came off, which I would rather you were straight about than diplomatic; I have been open with them about it.

No difficulty at all if you would rather not.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Giving the referee their brief. A reference who has not been told what the job needs will default to generalities, which are worthless. The unusual move is inviting them to be honest about the failure: it tells the referee they will not be put in the position of concealing something, which is the thing that makes people hesitate to say yes.

Chasing

Nearly every unanswered message is unanswered for a boring reason. It arrived on a bad morning. It needed a decision the person had not made, or twenty minutes they did not have. Then it moved down the screen and stopped existing. Almost none of it is about you. The sender, meanwhile, has spent four days building a theory in which the silence is a verdict on the work, or on the relationship, or on one sentence in the third paragraph that read differently than it was meant to.

Knowing that changes how the chase should be written, because the standard chase is built on the opposite assumption. It is apologetic, faintly wounded, and it re-explains the request at length. All three make it harder to answer. The apology says you think you are a nuisance. The woundedness turns a reply into an emotional task. And the re-explanation means four hundred words stand between the reader and the thing you want.

The chase that works is shorter than the original, contains the specific thing needed, and makes the reply as close to a single word as possible. If you can convert your request into a yes or no question, do it, even at the cost of some precision. A question that can be answered in three seconds from a phone at a bus stop will be answered.

The other reliable device is the deadline that is not a threat: *if I do not hear by Friday I will assume X and proceed*. It gives the reader permission to not reply. That sounds like the opposite of what you want, and it is the thing that produces a reply.

Three chases, then change medium. A fourth email will not work when the third did not.

026

“You have sent one email and heard nothing for a week.”

The first chase

THE LETTER

Sam,

Bumping this in case it got buried.

One question: are you happy for us to go ahead with the March date? Yes or no is enough, and I can work out the rest.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Brevity, and the conversion of the request into a binary. The original email probably asked for several things; the chase asks for the one that unblocks you. *In case it got buried* hands the reader a face-saving explanation. That matters. A reader who feels caught out delays again instead of replying.

027

“Somebody has gone silent in the middle of a piece of work.”

The disappearance

THE LETTER

Dear Priya,

I have not heard from you since the twelfth and I want to check in without making it awkward.

If something has come up, or the project has changed shape at your end, that is completely fine and I would rather know than guess. If you would like to hand it back, that is also a real option and I will not be difficult about it.

If I do not hear by Friday I will assume you would rather step away, and I will pick the work up from here with no hard feelings at all.

Genuinely, either way.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Offering the exit. Silence in the middle of a project is nearly always somebody who has fallen behind and cannot face saying so. Every further day makes the confession harder. Naming the escape route takes the shame out of it. It then produces the opposite of what it offers. People given permission to quit reply and carry on.

028

“A decision you need keeps slipping and you are getting impatient.”

Escalating without escalating

THE LETTER

Ruth,

The supplier decision has moved three times, most recently to the twenty-first. I am not chasing to hurry you; I know it is not straightforward.

What I do need is to understand what it is waiting on, because two things downstream depend on it and I would rather re-plan around a real date than keep holding.

If the honest answer is that it will not be resolved this quarter, tell me that and I will build the plan on the current supplier instead.

No rush on this reply, but a rough steer would help a lot.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Asking what it is waiting on, not when it will be done. A date can be given without thought and slip again. A blocker has to be described. Describing it produces either the decision or the real timeline. Offering to plan around the

failure is the pressure, and it is applied without anybody having to be criticised.

029

“A friend has stopped replying and you do not know why.”

The personal chase

THE LETTER

Tom,

I have sent two things and not heard back, which is unlike you, so I am doing the thing where I ask directly rather than working it out on my own and getting it wrong.

Is everything all right? And separately, have I done something? I would genuinely rather know than wonder, and if I have, I would like the chance to sort it.

If you are just under water, ignore this entirely and I will assume that.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Asking both questions and separating them. The two possibilities, *something is wrong with them* and *something is wrong between us*, need different letters. Most people write one and hope it covers both. Asking outright is uncomfortable for about a day and prevents the slow silent drift that ends friendships without anybody deciding to.

030

“Somebody owes you an answer about something that matters and keeps deflecting.”

Asking for a straight answer

THE LETTER

Dear Chris,

I have raised the question about the flat three times now and each time we have ended up talking about something else. I do not think that is deliberate, but I need to ask it plainly.

Are you intending to move out in April, or not? I am not asking you to justify the answer and I am not going to argue with it. I need to know because I have to give notice by the fourteenth either way.

If you do not know yet, tell me that and tell me when you will.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the pattern without accusing anybody of it, and then reducing the question to a single unavoidable sentence. The promise not to argue is what makes it answerable. Repeated deflection is somebody avoiding a row. Remove the row in advance and the reason to deflect goes with it.

IV

WHEN THE ANSWER IS NO



Declining

The reason saying no is hard is that most people believe a refusal needs to be earned, and that the way you earn it is with a reason good enough to survive scrutiny. So the letter fills up with explanation, and every additional reason is another surface for the other person to push against. *You could do it if you moved the Tuesday thing.* Now you are negotiating about your own diary with somebody who is not entitled to.

A refusal is not a proposal. It does not need agreement. Justification does not improve it. One reason, offered as information and not as a case, is the maximum. None at all is better still.

The second failure is the soft no. *Let me see if I can make it work. Maybe, let me check.* These are kind in the moment and unkind over a week, because they leave the other person planning around a maybe. The clean early no is the generous version, and people say so afterwards.

Three components. Decline in the first sentence, so nobody is reading in hope. Say one warm true thing, because a bare no reads as a judgement on the asker. And where you can, offer something smaller that you are willing to do. That last part is optional and does a great deal of work.

Then stop. The commonest error in a refusal is the third paragraph.

031

“Your manager has asked you to take on something and you have no capacity.”

Declining upwards

THE LETTER

Ruth,

I do not think I can take the Halden review on, and I would rather say so now than deliver it badly in April.

Right now I have the migration through to March and the audit follow-up, both of which have dates on them. Adding a third means one of the three slips, and I would rather you chose which than found out later.

If Halden is the priority, I can do it and move the audit follow-up to May. If the audit date is fixed, then it needs somebody else.

Happy either way, but I do not think all three fit.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Refusing without refusing: the no is real, and it is framed as a prioritisation question handed back to the person entitled to answer it. Managers respond badly to *I cannot* and well to *here is what it displaces*, because the second gives them the decision and the first takes it away.

032

“You have been invited to a wedding you do not want to attend.”

The declined invitation

THE LETTER

Dear Priya and James,

Thank you so much for the invitation. I am so sorry, but I will not be able to come.

DECLINING

I would have loved to be there and I am genuinely sorry to miss it. I hope the day is everything you want it to be, and I would love to take you both out when you are back and hear about all of it.

The present is in the post.

With love and every good wish,

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

No reason at all. A wedding decline with an explanation invites the couple to solve it, and any explanation short of a funeral will be weighed. The absence of one is read as *I cannot*, which is what you want, and the offer of the dinner afterwards is what stops the refusal reading as indifference. Note the answer arrives in the second sentence.

033

“Somebody keeps asking you to help and you keep saying yes.”

The repeat asker

THE LETTER

Dear Sam,

I am going to have to stop doing the newsletter after this issue.

I have done it for three years and I have enjoyed a lot of it, but it has grown from an evening a month to most of a weekend, and it has quietly become the thing I do instead of the things I meant to do.

I will do the March issue and I will write up how it all works so the next person is not starting from nothing. After that I am out, and I am afraid I do mean out rather than occasionally helping.

Thank you for asking me in the first place. It was good of you.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Closing the back door in advance. Somebody who has said yes for years is assumed to be available, so a refusal that leaves any opening will be tested. *I do mean out rather than occasionally helping* is uncomfortable to write and it is the sentence that makes the letter work. The handover offer is what keeps the relationship intact.

034

“You have been asked to do professional work for free.”

The free work request

THE LETTER

Dear Nadia,

Thank you for thinking of me. I am afraid I cannot do it on an unpaid basis.

This is not a comment on the project, which I like, or on you. It is that design is what I do for a living rather than in addition to it, and I have had to make it a rule because the exceptions took over.

My rate for something this size would be around eighteen hundred. If that is out of reach, I would be glad to spend half an hour on the phone giving you my honest view on the brief, at no charge, which might save you more than the design would.

With very best wishes,

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming a price instead of only refusing. It converts *no* into *here are the terms*, which is a different conversation and one that sometimes converts. The half hour offered free is the crucial softener: it demonstrates goodwill, costs little, and makes it plain that the refusal is about the work rather than about them.

035

“You do not want to, and you do not have a reason you want to give.”

Declining without explaining

THE LETTER

Chris,

Thanks for asking me, but I am going to say no to this one.

No dramatic reason, I just do not want to take it on at the moment.

Hope it goes well and do ask me another time.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Forty words, and *no dramatic reason* is the whole letter. Refusals without stated reasons make people anxious that something is being concealed, and one short line closes that off without inventing anything. *Do ask me another time* is the piece that keeps it from sounding like a door closing, and it is only fair to include if it is true.

Ending It

An ending letter has one job that people get wrong: it has to end the thing. A great many of them are written to be kind and end up being ambiguous, and ambiguity is the cruellest available option, because it leaves the other person doing the work of interpretation for weeks.

The kindness is real. It belongs elsewhere in the letter. Put the ending in the first two sentences, in the indicative, with no conditionals and no *I think* attached. Then be as warm as you truthfully can be about everything else. That order feels backwards while writing and is the right way round for reading.

The other error is the reason. Endings tempt people into a full account of everything that went wrong, on the theory that the other person is owed an explanation. Sometimes they are. But a comprehensive list of failings is not an explanation, it is a prosecution, and it is being delivered at the moment the person can do nothing about any of it. One honest reason is a kindness. Nine is an assault.

Do not ask them to understand. Do not ask them to agree it is for the best. And do not leave a door ajar you have no intention of opening, however much better it makes the paragraph feel.

036

“You are resigning.”

The resignation

THE LETTER

Dear Ruth,

I am writing to resign from my role as Operations Manager. My notice is three months, so my last day would be the fourteenth of June.

I have taken a position at the Trust. It is a step up in scope and it was not something I went looking for.

I want to say properly that these four years have been the best of my working life, and that most of what I can do now I learned here, a good deal of it from you.

I would like to leave this in a state where nobody is picking up loose ends. I will put together a handover plan this week and I am happy to be flexible about the date if a different one works better for the migration.

Thank you, genuinely.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The date in the first paragraph. A resignation that buries the leaving date makes the reader hunt for the only fact that matters. The warmth in the third paragraph is unqualified and therefore believable, and the handover offer is the thing that determines what people say about you for the next ten years, which is the actual purpose of a resignation letter.

037

“You are ending a business relationship with a client.”

Resigning the account

THE LETTER

Dear Sarah,

After a good deal of thought, we are going to step back from the account at the end of the current agreement on the thirtieth of April.

This is not about any single thing and it is not about money. It is that the work has moved a long way from what we are good at, and I would rather say so than keep doing it adequately.

Everything through to the thirtieth will be completed as agreed. I will also put together a full handover pack, and I am happy to speak to whoever picks it up.

I can recommend two firms who would be a better fit than us, if that would be useful.

It has been four years and I am grateful for all of them.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Declining to itemise. *Not about any single thing* pre-empts the reasonable question and refuses the row, and the honest reason offered instead is about fit rather than fault, which is both true and impossible to argue with. The recommendation of successors is what converts an ending into something the client remembers well.

038

“A friendship has become one-sided and you want to stop.”

Letting a friendship go

THE LETTER

Dear Chris,

I have been putting this off for a while.

I do not think I can carry on with the friendship as it is. For a long time now the contact has been in one direction, and the times we do speak are mostly about your situation. I have not minded that for stretches; I do mind that when things were bad for me last year you did not notice, and I have realised I stopped telling you.

I am not looking for an argument about whether that is fair and I am not asking you to fix it.

I am not angry with you. I am just tired, and I would rather step back honestly than keep drifting and pretending I am busy.

I hope things get easier for you. I mean that.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

One specific instance, not a general characterisation. *You are selfish* is arguable; *when things were bad for me you did not notice* is a fact and cannot be debated away. Declining the argument in advance is the part that makes it survivable for both of you, and the refusal to pretend to be busy is the honesty the letter turns on.

039

“You need distance from a family member.”

Asking for space, without a rupture

THE LETTER

Dad,

I am going to take a step back from contact for a while. I do not know how long and I am not going to pretend I do.

This is not about a single argument and there is nothing you can do this week to change it. It is that I come away from most of our conversations feeling smaller than when I went in, and I have stopped being able to absorb that.

I am not cutting you off and I am not asking anybody else in the family to take a side. I will be at Grandma's in June.

I will get in touch. Please do not ring in the meantime; it would make this harder rather than shorter.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Setting the terms out loud, including the one nobody remembers to set: what happens next, and who initiates it. Without that line the distance becomes a negotiation conducted through voicemail. Naming an event he will still

attend prevents the whole family reading it as a rupture, which is what escalates these.

040

“You are ending a relationship.”

The letter you should probably not send

THE LETTER

Rachel,

I am ending our relationship. I am sorry, and I know that reading it in writing is not what you deserve.

I have tried to say this to you three times and each time I have not managed it, and a fourth failed attempt seemed worse than this.

The reason is not a single thing you did. I have known for months that I am not in it in the way you are, and continuing while knowing that is the thing I am most ashamed of.

I will move my things out on Saturday while you are at your mother's, if that is easiest. I will pay the rent through to the end of the quarter.

If you want to talk, I will talk, whenever and for as long as you want.

I am sorry, Rachel.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Admitting that the medium is wrong, in the second sentence, and giving the true reason for it. This letter is here as the exception that proves the chapter: almost every ending of this size should happen face to face, and the only defensible version in writing is one that says so and gives the true reason instead of dressing the choice up as consideration.

V

MONEY

Money Between People

Money between friends is difficult for a reason that has nothing to do with money. Every other favour between friends is settled by reciprocity over time, without accounting. Money introduces a number, and a number cannot be settled that way. Either it comes back or it does not. Both of you know which. That is the whole difficulty in a line: an arrangement that used to run on goodwill and rough symmetry now runs on a figure that either appears in an account by a date or fails to, and goodwill has no way of settling it.

That is why these letters are the hardest in the book to write and the most avoided. The lender feels grasping for asking. The borrower feels shamed by being asked. And the friendship absorbs the difference. Both parties see less of each other, neither says why, and that is the outcome nobody wanted and everybody chose.

The single most useful principle here is to separate the money from the relationship out loud. Say that the friendship is not conditional on the money, and mean it. Then deal with the money with a number and a date, because vagueness is what allows the thing to fester.

The second principle is about lending: if you cannot afford to give it, you cannot afford to lend it. Every letter in this chapter is easier if that rule was applied at the start. Most of them exist because it was not.

041

“A friend borrowed money and has not mentioned it in four months.”

Asking for it back

THE LETTER

Chris,

This is awkward and I would rather be awkward than weird with you, so I am just going to say it.

Could I ask about the four hundred from October? I am not in trouble and there is no crisis, but it has been a while and I have noticed I have started thinking about it, which I do not want.

If it is difficult, tell me and we will do fifty a month, or whatever works. If you had genuinely forgotten, which is completely possible, then no problem at all.

It is not a big deal and it is not going to become one. I just did not want it sitting there unsaid.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the awkwardness, which drains most of it. Then the crucial admission: *I have started thinking about it, which I do not want*, which explains why the letter exists in terms of the friendship rather than the finances. Offering the instalment option before he has to ask removes the humiliation of having to propose it himself.

042

“A friend has asked to borrow money and you do not want to lend it.”

Refusing to lend

THE LETTER

Sam,

I am sorry, I am not going to be able to lend you the two thousand.

It is not about you and it is not about whether I think you would pay it back.

I made a rule some years ago about not lending money to people I want to stay friends with, after it went badly twice, and I have kept to it since.

What I can do: I can give you three hundred, as a gift, now, with nothing attached and no expectation of it coming back. And I am happy to sit down with the numbers with you this week if a second pair of eyes would help.

I know that is not what you asked for and I am sorry.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

A stated rule, not a judgement about this person. A rule is impersonal and cannot be argued with, and it lets the refusal avoid saying the unsayable thing about trust. The smaller gift is what stops the letter being a pure no. It is framed as a gift on purpose, so that it cannot become a second debt.

043

“Your friends are planning something you cannot afford.”

Saying you cannot afford it

THE LETTER

All,

The villa looks wonderful and I am going to have to sit this one out. It is more than I can spend this year.

I am telling you now rather than being vague about dates until it goes away, which is what I would normally do.

Please do book it without me, genuinely, and please do not adjust it to a cheaper thing on my account, because then I will feel worse about it than I do now.

Can we do something at mine in September instead? I will cook and it will cost nobody anything.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Saying the actual reason. The alternative, which is what most people do, is a fog of scheduling difficulties that everyone half-believes and that has to be maintained for months. Forbidding them to downgrade the trip is what prevents the second social cost, which is being the person who spoiled it, and the counter-offer keeps you in the group.

044

“You need to ask your parents for help.”

Asking family for money

THE LETTER

Mum, Dad,

I need to ask you for some help and I have been dreading writing this, which is why it is a letter.

The position is this: I am eleven hundred short on the deposit and the offer is conditional on completing by the eighth. I have exhausted the other options, including the ones you would ask me about.

What I am asking for is a loan of eleven hundred, which I would pay back at two hundred a month starting in April. I would like it to be a loan and I would like us to write down the terms, because I do not want it to become a thing that is never mentioned and always there.

If the answer is no, that is genuinely all right and I will not ask again.

I love you both.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Insisting on terms. Family money curdles because it is given without paperwork and then carries an unspoken interest rate paid in obligation for a decade. Asking for it to be documented is what protects the relationship, and it also signals seriousness in a way that no amount of gratitude does. Pre-empting *have you tried* saves a round of correspondence.

045

“Somebody always pays less than their share and nobody says anything.”

The unequal arrangement

THE LETTER

Priya,

Slightly uncomfortable subject, and I would rather raise it than get quietly annoyed about it, which is where I am heading.

With the house bills, I have been covering the internet and the standing charges as well as my half of everything else, and it has drifted into being the arrangement rather than a favour. It is about sixty a month.

I do not think this was deliberate at all. It is the sort of thing that just happens.

Could we redo the split from March, and I am happy to do the spreadsheet? And if there is a reason the current arrangement suits you that I do not know about, tell me and we will work something out.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Giving the other person an innocent explanation and an exit. *I do not think this was deliberate* is offered before any defence is needed, which prevents the conversation becoming about character. The offer to do the administrative work is what makes the change happen, and the closing question leaves room for a real reason to exist.

Money With Institutions

Writing to an organisation is a different craft. Nobody is reading it in the way you imagine. Your letter goes to somebody with a queue, a script and no great authority, and the outcome depends on making their job easy rather than on making them care.

That reframing changes almost everything. Emotion is the strongest tool in every other chapter of this book. Here it is close to useless, and it works against you. The person reading has been shouted at four times today and has the defences to prove it. What works instead is being the easiest correspondent in the queue.

Which means: dates, reference numbers, amounts, and one specific request. Say what happened, when, with the reference. Say what you want, as a number or an action. Say what you will do next if it is not resolved, without threatening. Keep it to one screen. What you are aiming at is a message that somebody with eleven minutes, four other cases and a screen full of mandatory fields can act on without having to ask you a single question, because every question they have to ask costs you a week.

The other thing worth knowing is that persistence beats force. Most complaints are abandoned at the second reply, and organisations are structured around that fact, by design or not. The person who sends a courteous fourth message with a reference number attached is in a small minority, and is treated as one.

“An invoice is six weeks overdue.”

The freelancer's chase

THE LETTER

Dear Accounts,

Invoice 2041, dated 3 January, for £2,400, is now 42 days overdue. Payment terms were 14 days.

Could you confirm the payment date? If there is a problem with the invoice, tell me what it is and I will correct it today.

For reference: the work was signed off by Sarah Miles on 20 December and the purchase order number is PO-88213.

If I have not had a payment date by Friday the 21st, I will invoke the Late Payment of Commercial Debts Act, which entitles me to statutory interest and a fixed recovery charge. I would much rather not and I do not expect it to be necessary.

With thanks,

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Every fact the accounts department needs to act, in one place: invoice number, date, amount, days overdue, sign-off, purchase order. Most chasers omit at least two of these and the reply is a request for them, which costs another week. The statutory reference is stated as a step you will take rather than as a threat, and *I would much rather not* is what keeps it from souring.

047

“Something you bought is faulty and you want your money back.”

The complaint that works

THE LETTER

Dear Sir or Madam,

Order 55-2093, placed 14 February. The dishwasher was delivered on the 22nd and has not completed a cycle without stopping.

Under the Consumer Rights Act 2015 I am within the thirty days for a full refund of £429, which is what I am requesting.

An engineer attended on 3 March, reference ENG-4471, and confirmed the fault is with the pump. I have the report.

Please confirm the refund and arrange collection. If it is easier for you to replace rather than refund, I am open to that provided it is delivered within seven days.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the legislation and the specific right, which moves the letter out of the discretionary pile and into the compliance pile. Offering the replacement as an alternative is the part people leave out. Give the organisation a cheaper way to satisfy you and the odds of a fast answer go up. You lose nothing by allowing it.

048

“You cannot pay a bill and it is going to get worse.”

Telling a creditor before they chase

THE LETTER

Dear Sir or Madam,

Account 40028811. I am writing before the next payment is due rather than after it, because I am not going to be able to make it.

My circumstances changed in January when I was made redundant. I have applied for benefits and I have a start date for new work in April.

What I am proposing: £40 a month for the next three months instead of £210, and a return to the full amount from May, with the arrears added at £30 a month from June.

I would rather agree something now than default. I can provide evidence of the redundancy and the new contract.

I am contactable on the number on the account any weekday.

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Arriving first. Creditors treat a proactive proposal as a different kind of file from a missed payment, because it moves the file out of collections and into arrangements. The proposal is specific, includes a return to normal, and deals with the arrears. That last part is the one people omit, and it decides whether the offer is accepted.

049

“There is a charge on your bill you did not agree to.”

Disputing a charge

THE LETTER

Dear Sir or Madam,

Account 7712-0043. The March bill includes a charge of £89.99 described as “Service Activation”. I did not request this service and I have no record of agreeing to it.

I am disputing the charge and asking for it to be removed and refunded.

I have checked my correspondence back to December and there is no confirmation email of the kind you send when a service is added. If you hold a recording or a record of my consent, please send it to me.

I have paid the remainder of the bill in full so that the account is not in arrears while this is resolved.

Please confirm within fourteen days.

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Paying the undisputed part. It removes their strongest lever, which is treating you as a defaulter. It also shows good faith, and that makes the dispute easier to concede. Asking them to produce the evidence of consent puts the burden where it belongs, and it is the sentence that ends it.

050

“You have complained twice and been fobbed off twice.”

Escalating properly

THE LETTER

Dear Sir or Madam,

Complaint reference CMP-90211, first raised 4 February, now seven weeks old.

I am asking for a deadlock letter or a final response so that I can refer this to the Ombudsman.

The history: I reported the fault on 4 February. I was told on the 19th that an engineer would attend within five working days; none did. On 12 March I was told the case had been closed, which nobody had informed me of. It was reopened on my call the same day.

WHAT TO SAY

I am not asking for anything beyond the original request, which was the repair and a refund of the two months of service charges, £58.

If a final response is not issued within eight weeks of the original complaint I will refer the matter regardless, as I am entitled to do.

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Asking for the deadlock letter. It signals that you know the regulatory process, and organisations behave differently towards a complainant who knows what it is. The dated chronology is the other half. The ombudsman will want it, and the company knows somebody outside the building will read it.

VI

WHEN NOTHING IS WRONG

Praise and Thanks

Almost all praise is wasted, and it is wasted the same way every time. It is general. It is delivered to the person alone. And it arrives in a form that asks for a modest deflection, after which both parties forget it within the hour.

Three changes make it stick. None of them costs anything.

Be specific about the thing. *You were great in that meeting* is pleasant and evaporates. *The way you rephrased Sarah's objection so she could back down from it without losing face* is a sentence somebody remembers for a decade. It tells them that a thing they did on purpose, and thought nobody saw, was seen.

Say what it did. Praise describes the performance; gratitude describes the effect. The second is rarer and it lands harder. It establishes that you were changed, and that is not something the recipient can shrug off.

And where it is safe to do so, say it to somebody else. Praise delivered to a person's manager, or to the room, does something private praise cannot: it changes their standing, not just their mood.

The last thing worth saying is about timing. These letters are almost never urgent, which is why they do not get written. There is no deadline on a thank you. So it waits. Then it is late, then it is awkward, then it does not happen at all. The letters in this chapter are therefore all a little late, which is realistic, and not one of them apologises for it, which is deliberate, because an apology for lateness invites the reader to think about the delay instead of about the thing you are thanking them for.

“Somebody did something significant for you and you said thanks in passing.”

The real thank you

THE LETTER

Dear Ruth,

I said thank you at the time and it was not adequate, so this is the proper version.

When I was falling apart in the autumn you did three things that I have thought about since. You moved the deadline without making me ask for it. You told me, in the corridor, that the work was still good, at a point when I had stopped believing that. And you never once mentioned it afterwards, which mattered more than either of the others.

I do not think you will remember any of this as anything much. It kept me in the job.

Thank you.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Three named actions, one of which the recipient may not have thought of as a decision at all. Naming the omission, the not mentioning it afterwards, is the strongest move available in a thank you. Restraint is invisible by design. Nobody is ever thanked for it. The last line does the other job: it says what it caused.

052

“A colleague did excellent work and their manager does not know.”

Praise where it counts

THE LETTER

Dear Adam,

I wanted to tell you about something Priya did last week, which I suspect she will not mention herself.

The Fenwick handover was in real trouble. She rebuilt the reconciliation from scratch over two days, found an error in our figures that had been there since November, and told the client about it before they found it themselves. That last part cost her a difficult conversation she could have avoided entirely.

I have worked with a lot of people who would have quietly fixed it and said nothing. She did the harder and better thing.

I thought you should know, from someone outside her team.

Murtaza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Writing to the manager instead of to her, and saying why: *from someone outside her team* is what gives it evidential weight. It also singles out the choice that involved a cost, which is the thing managers most struggle to see and most value hearing about. This letter changes somebody’s career and takes six minutes.

053

“A stranger’s work changed something for you.”

The unsolicited letter

THE LETTER

Dear Ms Adeyemi,

You will not know me. I read your book on the Windrush cases in 2023, when I was about to give up on a case of my own.

There is a passage near the end about how the evidence was reconstructed after the records were destroyed. I read it four times. It gave me an approach I had not thought of, and eighteen months later the case was decided in my client's favour.

I am not asking for anything. I have wanted to write this for two years and kept not doing it, and it seemed foolish to carry on not doing it.

Thank you for the book.

With respect,

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Asking for nothing, and saying so. Writers, artists and academics get a great deal of post that turns out to be a request in the fourth paragraph. A letter that closes off that possibility can be enjoyed instead of assessed. The specific passage is what proves the reading was real, and the outcome is what makes the letter worth having received.

054

“Somebody you are quietly jealous of has had good news.”

Congratulating properly anyway

THE LETTER

Sam,

Congratulations on the book. Genuinely, and I will admit that it took me a couple of days to be able to write this without it being through gritted teeth, which says everything about me and nothing about you.

You have wanted this since we were twenty-three and you did the work in a way I did not. I have watched you get up at five for four years and I have not, and the outcome is exactly correct.

Very well done. I mean it.

Ade

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Admitting the envy, with a light hand, and without making it the recipient's problem. The alternative, which is a warm letter with a detectable coolness underneath, is worse, because everybody can feel it and nobody can name it. Owning it disarms it and produces something more affectionate than an unmixed congratulation would have been.

055

“You are writing a reference for somebody you rate.”

The recommendation that helps

THE LETTER

Dear Ms Chen,

I am glad to be asked about Priya Nair and I will be more useful if I am specific rather than general.

She led the Fenwick migration for eighteen months. Two things are worth knowing. She is the only person I have managed who consistently brought me problems while they were still cheap to fix, including problems she had caused, which is rarer than it sounds and is the single quality I would most look for.

And she is a good manager of people who are struggling. Two members of her team were in difficulty during that period and both are still with us and doing well, which was her work.

Her weakness, since you will want one: she is slow to delegate and takes on more than she should. She knows this and has been working on it.

I would hire her again without hesitation.

Murtaza Raza

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The named weakness. A reference with no weakness in it reads as a formality and gets discounted. One honest, minor, self-known limitation makes everything else credible. The two strengths are behavioural and specific

WHAT TO SAY

instead of adjectival, which is the difference between a reference that is read and one that is skimmed.

Letters With No Purpose

Every other chapter in this book is about a letter with a job. Something has gone wrong, or something is needed, or something has to be refused, and the writing is the instrument that handles it. This chapter is about the letters that have no job at all, which are the ones almost nobody writes and the ones people keep.

If you doubt that, look at what survives in other people's houses. Nobody keeps a delivery confirmation. The shoebox on top of the wardrobe holds the letter somebody wrote for no reason, and it has been read more times than its author would believe.

The reason these go unwritten is not laziness. It is that the ordinary rules of correspondence assume an occasion, and without one there is a faint embarrassment about writing at all. What am I doing, exactly. Why now. That hesitation is answered by the letters in this chapter, all of which are written on the same principle: the occasion is that you thought of them, and you are allowed to say so.

The commonest form of this failure is the letter that is delayed until the person can no longer read it. Nearly every funeral in the world contains somebody standing at the front saying true and loving things to a room, having never once said them to the person concerned. It is not that they did not mean it. It is that there was never a Tuesday that seemed like the right Tuesday.

There is one letter here that is never sent. It belongs in a book about what to say because a great deal of what needs saying is not addressed to anybody who should have to read it, and writing it down anyway does

most of the work. The unsent letter is not a trick or an exercise. It is the correct form for a certain kind of thing.

Two practical notes. Write these by hand if you can, because a letter with no purpose that arrives by email reads as a message, and the physical version is the one that gets kept. And do not apologise for writing. An opening line that excuses the letter tells the reader it was an odd thing to do, which is exactly the belief this chapter is trying to break.

056

“Nothing has happened. You simply thought about somebody on a Tuesday.”

The letter with no occasion

THE LETTER

Dear Nan,

No news, no reason. I was making tea in a mug you gave me about nine years ago, which is now chipped at the handle and is still the one I reach for first, and I thought I would write and tell you that.

Work is fine. The flat is cold. I have started running, badly, on Sunday mornings, and I keep thinking about you saying that the first mile is rent and the rest is yours.

That is genuinely all. You do not have to write back, though I would love it if you did, and I am not building up to asking you for anything.

I think about you a lot. I hope you are warm.

Love, Ruth

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The chipped mug. Anyone can write *thinking of you*, and it evaporates on contact, because it is a sentiment with no evidence attached. An object, a chip on the handle, a habit you have kept for nine years: these prove the thought was real and located somewhere in an actual afternoon. The second move is the disclaimer near the end, which sounds throwaway and is not. Older relatives in particular have learned that an unexpected letter can precede a request, and saying outright that nothing is coming lets the letter be what it is.

057

“A teacher, a boss, an aunt. Somebody who changed the direction of your life and has never been told.”

The letter you owe a living person

THE LETTER

Dear Mr Okonjo,

You taught me GCSE physics between 2003 and 2005, in the lab at the end of the science corridor, and I doubt you remember me. I sat at the back and I was not a good student.

I am writing because I want to tell you something while it is still possible to tell you.

In the spring of the second year you kept me back after a lesson and said that I was lazy rather than stupid, and that the difference was entirely in my hands and nobody else's. You were not kind about it. It was the first time an adult had told me the truth about myself in a way I could not argue with.

I am an engineer. I have been one for fourteen years. I do not think that happens without that conversation, and I have never told you, which seemed increasingly ridiculous the longer it went on.

Thank you. I hope the corridor is still standing.

With real gratitude, Daniel Achebe

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The precision. Naming the years, the room, the season and the actual sentence spoken converts a vague tribute into a piece of evidence the reader can check against their own memory, and that is what makes it land rather than embarrass. Note also that the letter does not soften what was said. Reporting the moment as it was, including the fact that it was not kind, is what makes the gratitude credible. And the reason for writing is stated in one line without decoration: while it is still possible.

058

“A friendship ended in nothing. No row, no falling out, just years.”

The letter after a long drift

THE LETTER

Dear Priya,

It has been about six years, I think, which is absurd.

Nothing happened, is the thing. We did not fall out. You moved, I had the twins, we each let three or four messages go unanswered at a busy time, and then enough time passed that writing started to feel like an event, and I kept not doing it.

I am writing now because I heard a song in the car that we both liked in a year I would rather not name out loud, and I sat in the car park until it finished.

I do not know what you want from this, and there may be nothing. If you would rather leave it where it is, that is genuinely all right and I will not chase.

But I miss you, and I did not want another six years to go by with nobody having said so.

Priya, I hope life has been good. Meera

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

Naming the absence of a cause. A long silence between friends acquires, in both heads, an imagined reason, and the fear that a letter will excavate it is what keeps people quiet for decades. Saying outright that nothing happened dissolves the thing that was never there. The other necessary move is the exit offered near the end. A letter that reopens a friendship by force is a demand, and it is much easier to answer one that has already told you it will accept a no.

059

“You want to leave something for your children to read when you are no longer here.”

The letter for afterwards

THE LETTER

To Sam and Isabel, to be read afterwards,

If you are reading this then the thing we all knew would happen eventually has happened, and I am sorry, and I am also fine about it, and both of those are true at once.

I want you to know three things.

The first is that I was happy. Not always, and not evenly, but on the whole and by a wide margin, and most of that was the two of you and your mother. If you find yourself worrying that I did not know that at the time, I did. I knew it constantly.

The second is that you are not obliged to grieve in any particular way, or for any particular length of time, or to agree with each other about how it is done. Look after each other through it and forgive whatever gets said in the first fortnight.

The third is about the house and the boat and all of it, and it is this: it is only money and objects, and I would rather you had a bad year and stayed close than divided everything correctly and did not speak again. If it comes to a choice, choose each other. That is an instruction.

Go and have a good life. It goes quickly and it is worth it.

All my love, always, Dad

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The permission. Almost everything a letter like this can do is release the reader from an obligation they will otherwise carry: to have made you happy enough, to grieve properly, to honour your memory by falling out over an estate. Listing three things and numbering them is not a stylistic tic either. A letter read in the worst week of somebody's life needs to be navigable, and structure survives distress in a way that flowing prose does not.

060

“You are furious with somebody who cannot hear it, or who is dead, or with whom the conversation would cost more than it is worth.”

The letter with no recipient

THE LETTER

Dad,

I am not going to send this and you are not going to read it, and I have decided that does not make it pointless.

You were not there. Not in the large way people mean when they say it about fathers, but in a hundred small verifiable ways: the Tuesday nights, the two years of Saturdays, the concert with the empty seat that I could see from the stage. I have carried a version of you in my head that I have been arguing with for twenty years, and the arguing has been going about as well as it went in life.

Here is what I actually wanted. I wanted you to be interested. Not proud, particularly. Interested.

I am forty-one. You have been dead for three. I am not going to get it, and I have spent a considerable amount of my one life waiting to be given a thing by somebody who did not have it to give.

So this is me putting it down. Not forgiving you, because I am not sure I do, and I am tired of being told that is the required destination. Just putting it down.

Goodbye.

Nathan

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK

The absence of a reader. Every other letter in this book is shaped by what it will do to the person who opens it, and that constraint, useful everywhere else, is what prevents this from being said at all. Removing the recipient removes the negotiation. Notice too that it refuses the expected ending. An unsent letter that arrives on cue at forgiveness is performing, and the honest

LETTERS WITH NO PURPOSE

version stops at the true place, which here is setting the thing down. That is a real outcome and it is enough.

A Note on Using These

A few things that did not fit in the chapters, and one warning.

Every name in this book is invented

There are no real people here. Not one. The situations are composites of the ordinary kinds of trouble that arrive in an average life, and the names, dates, places, employers and account numbers were made up to fill them out. Any resemblance to a specific person's circumstances is a consequence of those circumstances being common, which is the point of the book.

How to adapt one

Read the letter. Read the note underneath it. Then put the book down and write your own, from memory, in the voice you would use on the telephone to somebody you had not spoken to for a month. That sounds like extra work. It is the fastest route to something that sounds like you.

If you would sooner work straight from the text, change these things at minimum. The opening line, because it is the most recognisable part of any letter. Every concrete detail, since borrowed specifics are worse than none at all. A memory that is not yours will read as false to the one person who knows it did not happen. And the register, which in this book is British, a shade formal and a little dry. If you do not talk like that, do not write like that.

What you should keep is the order of the moves and the things that are absent. The absences are the hardest part to reproduce from instinct, because under pressure everybody adds.

The letters that are meant to be difficult

Chapters seven, eight and ten contain letters that will not make the recipient happy, and they are not written to. A refusal that has been softened until it can be misread as a maybe has failed at the only thing it was for. If you find yourself adding a sentence to make one of those letters kinder, stop and check what it is doing. Kinder, or vaguer? The two are easy to confuse and only one of them is a mercy.

On sending things by email

Most of these work by email, and several are better that way: anything involving a company, a deadline or a record. Four kinds are not, and are worth a stamp. Condolence. Thanks that matter. Anything intended to be kept. And any letter whose whole purpose is to show that you took some trouble, since an email costs nothing and shows it.

The one warning

A letter is not a substitute for a conversation with somebody who is present and available. It is tempting to write instead of speaking, because writing can be edited and a person cannot, and there are relationships that have been emptied out, without a word, by one party handling everything difficult in prose. If the person is in the next room, go and talk to them. This book is for the moments when that is not possible, has already failed, or would put more on somebody than they can carry in real time.

Index of Situations

A

- After a redundancy 13
- Apologising for your reaction 28
- The apology for something you meant 20
- Asking a stranger 34
- Asking family for money 64
- Asking for a name 37
- Asking for a straight answer 42
- Asking for it back 62
- Asking for money from your employer 34
- Asking for something you find humiliating to need 36
- Asking for space, without a rupture 56
- Asking someone to spend their credibility 35
- Asking to be taken off it 29

B

- Bad news, early 26

C

- The client apology 27

- The complaint that works 69
- Condolence, after a long silence 8
- Condolence, at a distance 6
- Condolence, for a loss others may not name 7
- Condolence, late 9
- Condolence, where you knew them 6
- Congratulating properly anyway 78
- The correction 22

D

- The declined invitation 48
- Declining upwards 48
- Declining without explaining 51
- The disappearance 40
- Disputing a charge 70

E

- Escalating properly 71
- Escalating without escalating 41
- Escalating your own error 26

WHAT TO SAY

F

The first chase 40

The forgotten occasion 21

The free work request 50

The freelancer's chase 68

I

The illness with no end date 15

L

The late apology 23

The letter after a long drift 84

The letter for afterwards 85

The letter with no occasion 82

The letter with no recipient 86

The letter you owe a living person 83

The letter you should probably not
send 57

Letting a friendship go 55

P

The personal chase 42

Praise where it counts 77

Professional apology, where there are
consequences 21

R

The real thank you 76

The recommendation that helps 79

Refusing to lend 62

The repeat asker 49

The resignation 54

Resigning the account 54

S

Saying you cannot afford it 63

T

Telling a creditor before they chase 70

To a parent, mid-crisis 14

U

The unequal arrangement 65

The unsolicited letter 77

W

When you do not know whose side to
take 13

Writing to someone who is ill 12



What to Say

Three hundred and fifteen entries across twenty-one chapters,
drawn from a hundred and fifty-one sources.

Set in EB Garamond, cut by Octavio Pardo
after the types of Claude Garamont and Robert Granjon.

